

CITY SIMULATION SYSTEM

Actions — Mechanical Reference

Working Document v0.1 • Baseline Draft

13 Actions • 3 Categories • Edge / Grit Resolution

Growth • Intelligence • Conflict • v0.2

1. Overview

Actions are the mechanical moves available to units and factions each cycle. Every action uses the base resolution formula when opposed. Unopposed actions resolve automatically but may still generate consequences.

Base Formula (reminder)

Result = (Domain Rating × 3) + Edge or Grit + Random (−3 to +3). Edge applies to active/offensive actions. Grit applies to defensive/resistance actions. Higher result wins. Ties go to the defender.

Action Categories

Growth Actions	Grow, Assist, Entrench — building and embedding power over time
Intelligence Actions	Spy, Obscure, Expose — information and concealment
Conflict Actions	Block, Attack, Steal, Defend, Contest, Recruit, Seek Leadership — direct opposition and organizational moves

Action Gates

Some actions cannot be taken until a prerequisite is met. Gates exist to ensure that aggression requires intelligence first — the system rewards preparation and punishes recklessness.

Spy gate	Block (Specific), Attack, Steal, and Expose all require a prior successful Targeted Spy against the specific target. No exceptions.
Domain gate	A unit must have at least Level 1 in a domain to take any action in that domain.
Steal domain gate	A unit must already hold Level 1 in the domain they are stealing into before a Steal action can be attempted.
Leadership gate	Seek Leadership requires the unit to be a member of the target faction.
Entrench gate	Entrench action requires the unit to hold at least Level 2 in the target domain.

Trait Weights & Action Selection

For NPC units the system selects actions using weighted random probability driven by traits. Traits load the dice toward certain action types without locking the outcome. A 3-5% wildcard weight exists on every unit ensuring occasional surprising behavior. Trait weights shift based on current tension level and active goals.

Expansionary	Weights toward Grow, Contest, Steal
Cautious	Weights toward Defend, Obscure, Spy
Revengeful	Weights toward Attack, Block when tension is high
Satisfied	Weights toward Defend, Assist — resists Grow and Attack
Opportunistic	Weights toward Contest, Steal, Spy — scans for openings
Loyal	Weights toward Assist (faction), Defend (faction assets)
Ambitious	Weights toward Seek Leadership, Grow, Spy
Callous	Weights toward Attack, Block — ignores collateral cost

2. Growth Actions

GROW	Type Growth	Stat Used Edge	Gated By None
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Grow increases a unit or faction's domain rating over time. It is the primary long-term action and the foundation of all power accumulation. Progress is tracked as a decimal — a unit growing from Level 4 to Level 5 passes through 4.25, 4.50, 4.75 before reaching 5.00. For resolution purposes a unit always acts at their whole number floor.

Decimal Progress & Display

- Each cycle of uninterrupted Grow adds a fixed increment to the decimal based on the total cycles required for that level transition.
- Example: Level 2 → 3 takes 4 cycles. Each cycle adds 0.25. After 2 cycles the unit is at 2.50.
- Display as percentage for readability: Street 4.67 = 67% of the way to Street 5.
- For all contest resolution, the unit acts at their whole number floor — a 4.67 unit acts as a 4.

Grow Timers

Level 1 → 2	2 cycles (+0.50 per cycle)
Level 2 → 3	4 cycles (+0.25 per cycle)
Level 3 → 4	8 cycles (+0.125 per cycle)
Level 4 → 5	16 cycles (+0.0625 per cycle)
Level 5 → 6	24 cycles
Level 6 → 7	36 cycles
Level 7 → 8	52 cycles
Level 8 → 9	72 cycles
Level 9 → 10	100 cycles — effectively generational

Interruption — Disruption Tokens

If a unit diverts a Grow action to any other purpose mid-progress, a Disruption Token is placed on that domain rating. Each token subtracts 0.10 from current decimal progress immediately and adds the equivalent of 2 cycles to remaining growth time. Tokens are removed one per cycle when the unit returns the domain to Grow.

Multi-Cycle Visibility — Spy Resistance Decay

The longer a Grow action runs, the more infrastructure it creates and the harder it becomes to conceal. Spy resistance against any multi-cycle action decreases as a function of completion percentage:

0–25% complete	Full Obscure resistance applies. Nothing visible yet.
26–50% complete	Obscure resistance –1. Patterns are emerging.
51–75% complete	Obscure resistance –2. Visible to anyone paying attention.
76–99% complete	Obscure resistance –3. Hard to miss. Infrastructure is real and named.

100% complete	Action complete. No longer spyable as in-progress.
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This rule applies uniformly to ALL multi-cycle actions — Grow, Block, Recruit, Steal in progress. The percentage used is always completion of the current action, not the domain rating decimal.

Domain Cap Resistance

As a domain approaches its cap, Grow actions face increasing resistance from existing power holders. At 85%+ cap utilization, every Grow action is automatically contested by the domain's highest-rated unit — even if no explicit Block has been declared. The domain itself pushes back.

Under 60% cap	Grow resolves unopposed. Timers run normally.
60–85% cap	Grow faces passive resistance. Timer adds 1 cycle per attempt that fails to beat domain average.
85–95% cap	Grow is automatically contested each cycle by highest domain unit. Timer pauses on failed contests.
95%+ cap	Grow impossible without first reducing another unit's rating via Attack or Steal.

Level Change & Entrench

When a unit successfully completes a Grow action and their whole number rating increases, their Entrench score adjusts:

Growing UP one level	New Entrench = current Entrench × 0.25. Unfamiliar territory — most roots lost.
Knocked DOWN one level	New Entrench = current Entrench × 1.25 (capped at 1.00). Returning to known ground — roots deepen.

Trait Interaction

Expansionary: –20% to all Grow timers while below 80% cap.

Satisfied: +30% to all Grow timers — low motivation to push.

Cautious: Pauses Grow automatically when under Attack rather than continuing.

ASSIST	Type Growth	Stat Used Edge	Gated By None
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Assist dedicates a unit's action to accelerating another unit or faction's Grow action, or boosting another unit's action this cycle. Assist is the primary cooperative action in the system.

Assisting a Grow Action

- Every level of the assisting unit's relevant domain rating reduces the target's remaining Grow timer by 10%, rounded down.
- A Level 5 Assist on a Grow action reduces remaining time by 50%.
- Multiple units can Assist the same Grow action. Effects stack, capped at 80% total reduction.

Assisting an Active Action

- The assisting unit adds half their relevant domain rating (rounded down) to the target unit's result this cycle only.
- This is not a Combine — the units remain separate and the bonus is additive, not multiplicative.

Exposure Cost

Assisting another unit opens both parties to intelligence gathering. After an Assist action, the assisting unit gains partial insight into the target's infrastructure. Any future Spy action by the assistant against the assisted unit operates at +1 effective domain level for one full year.

Assist vs. Combine

Assist adds half the assisting unit's level to the target's result.

Combine merges two equal ratings into one level higher — far more powerful.

Combine also creates full mutual exposure. Assist creates one-way partial exposure.

Use Assist when you want to help but protect yourself.

Use Combine only when you fully trust the other unit.

Trait Interaction

Loyal: Assist actions toward Primary Faction cost no exposure penalty.

Callous: Can Assist at full domain level rather than half — but burns the relationship permanently.

ENTRENCH

Type
Growth

Stat Used
Grit

Gated By
Level 2+ in
domain

Entrench deepens a unit's roots in a domain they already hold. It is the action of consolidating power rather than expanding it — building relationships, embedding infrastructure, making a position costly for rivals to dislodge. Every unit and faction has an Entrench score per domain, tracked as a decimal from 0.00 to 1.00.

Entrench Score

0.00–0.25

Vulnerable. Fresh or damaged. Rating drop risk if Entrench hits zero at both start and end of cycle. Easy to Attack and Steal.

0.26–0.50	Establishing. Building roots. Maintenance costs moderate. Steal resistance starting to matter.
0.51–0.75	Settled. Comfortable in the domain. Maintenance costs low. Attack and Steal face real resistance.
0.76–1.00	Deeply embedded. Institutional presence. Nearly self-maintaining. Very costly to dislodge.

The Entrench Action

- Costs one full action slot.
- On completion: +0.10 to Entrench score in target domain.
- Cannot take any other action this cycle — including defensive actions.
- Can be taken in any domain where the unit holds Level 2 or above.
- For Social Media: also prevents decay at Level 3+. This is the SM-specific version of the action.

Natural Entrench Rates

Every domain has a natural entrench drift each cycle — either building or decaying — that applies passively regardless of whether the unit takes an Entrench action:

Religion	Strong natural growth (+0.06/cycle) — congregations deepen over time
Bureaucracy	Moderate growth (+0.04/cycle) — civil servants dig in
University	Moderate growth (+0.04/cycle) — tenure and reputation compound
Finance	Slow growth (+0.02/cycle) — money is sticky
Traditional Media	Very slow decay (−0.02/cycle) — institutions are durable but erode
Legal	Slow decay (−0.02/cycle) — relationships shift with cases
Political	Slow decay (−0.03/cycle) — alliances are temporary
Health	Neutral (0.00/cycle) — stable but not self-reinforcing
Industry	Slow decay (−0.03/cycle) — markets and labor shift
High Society	Moderate decay (−0.04/cycle) — social standing requires maintenance
Street	Moderate decay (−0.04/cycle) — neighborhood dynamics shift
Underworld	Moderate decay (−0.05/cycle) — people disappear, allegiances shift
Police	Moderate decay (−0.04/cycle) — command structures rotate
Transportation	Slow decay (−0.03/cycle) — infrastructure changes
Social Media	High decay (−0.08/cycle) — audience is fickle, always eroding

The Zero Floor Rule

If a unit's Entrench score is at 0.00 at both the START and END of a cycle — meaning no action built it up and natural decay did not help — their domain rating drops by 0.10. They are losing their grip. The domain fills in around them. Nobody maintains a position by doing nothing.

What Builds and Drains Entrench

Entrench action	+0.10
Successful Defend action	+0.08
Cycle without being attacked	+ domain natural rate
Being faction leader in domain	+0.05 per cycle
Assist from allied unit	+0.04
Domain natural growth rate	+ per cycle (domain dependent)
Domain natural decay rate	– per cycle (domain dependent)
Surviving an Attack	–0.15 (even winning costs)
Disruption Token on Grow	–0.05 per token
Leaderless faction member	–0.08 per cycle
High SM Attention in domain	–0.05 per cycle above Elevated

Entrench & Defense/Steal Resistance

Entrench score adds directly to Grit resistance when defending against Attack and Steal actions. A deeply entrenched unit is mechanically harder to move — not just narratively.

Entrench 0.00–0.25	No bonus to resistance.
Entrench 0.26–0.50	+1 to Grit resistance vs Attack and Steal.
Entrench 0.51–0.75	+2 to Grit resistance vs Attack and Steal.
Entrench 0.76–1.00	+3 to Grit resistance vs Attack and Steal.

Trait Interaction

Satisfied: Natural decay rates are halved for this unit — comfortable and stable.

Expansionary: Entrench action also generates +0.03 to Grow decimal progress — digging in also builds.

Cautious: +0.05 bonus to Entrench action result — careful units build roots deliberately.

Loyal: +0.05 Entrench per cycle when acting primarily in support of faction goals.

3. Intelligence Actions

SPY	Type Intelligence	Stat Used Edge	Gated By None
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Spy is the intelligence-gathering action and the prerequisite gate for all aggressive actions. A unit cannot Block (specific), Attack, Steal, or Expose a rival until a successful Targeted Spy has been completed against that rival's relevant activity.

Passive Spy

- Operates at half the unit's domain rating, rounded down.
- Can only observe units in the same domain.
- Reveals general activity only — the unit is growing, the faction is moving — not specifics.
- Does NOT satisfy the Spy gate for aggressive actions.

Targeted Spy

- Directed at a specific unit, faction, or activity.
- Operates at full domain rating.
- May cross domains if the logic holds and can be argued.
- On success: reveals who, what, where, when, and why.
- On failure: may alert the target that someone is watching — treat as partial success for target's intelligence.
- Satisfies the Spy gate for Block (specific), Attack, Steal, and Expose against that target.

Resolution

Targeted Spy is resolved as a contested roll. Attacker rolls Edge. Target's effective resistance is their domain rating + current Obscure level (if any). If target has a Defend action active on that domain, add Grit to resistance.

Intelligence Sharing

A unit may share successful Spy results with an allied unit. The recipient treats the shared intelligence as satisfying the Spy gate — they may take aggressive action against the target without completing their own Spy. This is the primary mechanical value of alliances.

Trait Interaction

Cautious: Passive Spy operates at 75% of domain rating rather than 50%.

Opportunistic: Successful Spy reveals one additional piece of information — specifically any active Power Vacuums connected to the target.

Ambitious: Spy actions against faction leaders operate at +1 effective domain level.

OBSCURE

Type
Intelligence

Stat Used
Grit

Gated By
None

Obscure conceals a unit's activities and misdirects anyone attempting to spy on them. It is a partial action — paid for by splitting the unit's domain rating between the action being concealed and the concealment itself. A unit cannot Obscure at full strength while also acting at full strength. These are the same resource.

Self-Obscure

- Unit splits their domain rating between action and concealment.
- Example: Domain 6 unit takes an action at Domain 4 and dedicates 2 levels to Obscure.
- Any Spy against that action must beat an effective resistance of 4 (the Obscure level) to penetrate it.
- The acting unit is always operating below full effectiveness when self-obscuring.

Cross-Domain Obscure

- A unit may use a different domain rating to Obscure an action in another domain.
- Example: Legal 4 unit obscures Underworld activity. Adds Legal level to Obscure resistance.
- This is expensive — the obscuring unit spends their full action on concealment only.
- Most effective when the concealing domain is higher than the acting domain.

Obscure Visibility

The Obscure level is visible to the GM/system but never directly to rival units. Rivals only learn whether their Spy succeeded or failed — not what the Obscure level was. A failed Spy against a well-Obscured action reveals nothing and may reveal that the spy was detected.

The Core Tension

A perfectly concealed operation is a weak operation.

A fully committed operation is fully visible.

Every point spent on hiding is a point not spent on doing.

This trade-off is the heart of covert play.

Trait Interaction

Cautious: Obscure costs are halved — a Domain 6 Cautious unit can act at Domain 5 and Obscure at 3 rather than splitting evenly.
Callous: Cannot Obscure — trait represents visible, consequence-ignoring action style.
Loyal: Can use faction's domain rating to Obscure own actions when acting in faction's interest.

EXPOSE

Type
Intelligence

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
Targeted Spy
(SM only)

Expose is the action used to unmask an Anonymous Social Media unit. It is a targeted intelligence action that reveals the identity of an Anon unit, converting their trait from Anonymous to Named and triggering potential cascade consequences across every domain they operate in.

Requirements

- A successful Targeted Spy against the Anon unit must be completed first.
- The Spy action in this case specifically targets identity — not activity.
- Expose is a separate subsequent action, not part of the Spy itself.

Resolution

Attacker rolls Edge + SM rating. Target resists with Grit + SM rating + Anonymous protection bonus (effective doubling of Grit for this contest). If attacker wins, identity is revealed publicly.

Consequences of Successful Expose

- Anon trait is permanently removed. Unit is now Named.
- All past anonymous actions are now potentially traceable to the identified unit.
- Every domain the unit operates in takes a stability check.
- The Expose itself is a high-Attention SM event — generates Attention spike.
- Factions previously targeted by the Anon unit now have a named enemy.

Trait Interaction

Opportunistic: +2 on Expose actions — they move fast on revealed vulnerabilities.
Revengeful: +2 on Expose if the Anon unit has previously targeted this unit.

4. Conflict Actions

BLOCK

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
Targeted Spy
(Specific only)

Block slows or halts a rival's activity in a domain. It comes in two forms with meaningfully different mechanics.

City-Wide Block

- A general interference applied across an entire domain of activity in the city.
- Operates at half the blocking unit's domain rating, rounded down.
- Affects ALL units attempting that activity in that domain — not just one.
- Does NOT require a prior Spy action.
- Any unit whose relevant domain rating does not exceed the Block level is slowed or stopped.
- City-Wide Block generates Attention — it is a visible, city-scale action.

Specific Block

- Targeted interference against one known rival unit or faction's specific action.
- Requires a prior successful Targeted Spy against that unit's activity.
- Operates at full domain rating.
- Affects only the specific action it is directed at.
- More powerful and more surgical than City-Wide Block.

Duration

Block continues until the blocking unit cancels it, is defeated, diverts their action, or a rival successfully overcomes it. A Block held over multiple cycles ties up the blocking unit's action slot each cycle it is maintained.

Countering a Block

A Specific Block against the City-Wide Block resolves as a contested roll. The counter unit must exceed the Block level with their own domain rating to lift it.

Trait Interaction

Callous: City-Wide Block also affects allied units in the domain — Callous units do not discriminate.

Cautious: Will not initiate City-Wide Block — too visible. Prefers Specific Block.

Expansionary: Lifts own Block automatically when domain drops below 70% cap — pressure relieved.

ATTACK

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
Targeted Spy
required

Attack is an attempt to permanently reduce a rival unit's domain rating. It is the most direct form of aggression in the system and carries real risk of retaliation. A successful Attack reduces the target's relevant domain rating by 1. A rating cannot be reduced below 1.

Requirements

- A prior successful Targeted Spy against the target's relevant domain activity.
- The attacking unit must have at least Level 2 in the relevant domain.

Resolution

Attacker rolls Edge + domain rating. Defender rolls Grit + domain rating + any active Defend bonus. If attacker wins by 3 or more — decisive result, rating drops immediately. If attacker wins by less than 3 — partial result, rating becomes Unstable (–1 on all rolls in that domain until stabilized). If defender wins — Attack fails, attacker is exposed as the source.

Margin 3+	Decisive. Target domain rating drops by 1 immediately.
Margin 1–2	Partial. Target domain becomes Unstable. –1 on all rolls until repaired.
Tie	Defender holds. Attacker identity may be revealed.
Defender wins	Attack fails. Attacker is exposed. Target may retaliate next cycle without a new Spy.

Infrastructure Attacks

An Attack can be directed at a unit's named infrastructure rather than their domain rating directly. This bypasses the normal Attack roll and instead removes a Supporting Ability or Background, triggering the Unstable condition without reducing the rating. Requires specific knowledge of the infrastructure obtained via Targeted Spy.

Recovery

A unit that loses domain rating levels due to Attack does not repurchase them. They rebuild via Grow actions. The rating is not gone — it is damaged and must be repaired through play.

Trait Interaction

Revengeful: +2 Edge on Attack against a unit that has previously damaged this unit.

Callous: Attack also damages one allied unit of the target's faction — collateral damage.

Cautious: Will not Attack unless tension is at maximum threshold.

Opportunistic: If Attack succeeds, immediately checks for Power Vacuum opportunity in that domain.

STEAL

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
Targeted Spy

required

Steal is a transfer action. A successful Steal reduces the target's domain rating by 1 and increases the attacker's equivalent domain rating by 1. It is more powerful than Attack but significantly riskier — Steal always leaves a traceable trail.

Requirements

- A prior successful Targeted Spy against the target.
- The stealing unit must already hold at least Level 1 in the domain they are stealing into.
- The stealing unit must have the infrastructure capacity to hold the stolen level.
- If infrastructure capacity is insufficient, the stolen level reverts to the original owner with no penalty to either party.

Resolution

Resolved identically to Attack. On decisive success, one domain level transfers from target to attacker. On partial success, target rating becomes Unstable but no transfer occurs. On failure, attacker is exposed.

The Traceable Trail

- A failed Steal attempt is almost always detected by the target.
- A successful Steal has a 50% chance of being traced within two cycles.
- Tracing a Steal satisfies the Spy gate — the traced target may retaliate without a new Spy.
- Cross-domain Steal (using Street muscle to steal Political influence) increases trace chance to 75%.

Trait Interaction

Opportunistic: Trace chance reduced by 20% — they are careful and fast.

Callous: Trace chance increased by 20% — they do not cover their tracks.

Ambitious: May Steal Leadership rating from a faction leader directly — see Seek Leadership.

DEFEND

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Grit

Gated By
None

Defend fortifies a domain rating against incoming Attack or Steal actions. Any unit attempting to Attack or Steal a Defended domain must overcome the Defend rating before their action can take effect.

Self-Defend

- A unit splits their domain rating between acting and defending — identical to Obscure splitting.

- Example: Domain 6 unit acts at Domain 4 and Defends at Domain 2.
- Any Attack or Steal against that domain must beat a resistance of Grit + domain rating + 2 (Defend bonus).

Cross-Domain Defend

- A different domain rating can Defend a target domain at full strength.
- Example: Legal 5 defends Political 7 — adds 5 to Political resistance against Attack.
- Cross-domain Defend draws attention — a watching unit's Spy action reveals something is being protected, even if not what or why.

Faction Defend

- A faction may dedicate its full domain rating to Defend a member unit's rating.
- This is a faction-level action consuming the faction's action slot for that cycle.
- Extremely powerful but makes the faction's protective role visible.

Trait Interaction

Cautious: Defend actions add +2 to resistance — heightened protective instinct.

Satisfied: Defend is the default action when no other trigger fires — always defending.

Loyal: Defending a faction member adds +2 to resistance — fierce protection of their own.

Revengeful: -1 to Defend when actively pursuing a retaliation target — divided attention.

CONTEST

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
Power Vacuum
active

Contest is the action used to claim a Power Vacuum — the window of opportunity that opens when a dominant unit collapses or vacates a domain position. Contest is a free action available to all units in adjacent domains during the Vacuum window, but only one unit may ultimately claim the abandoned infrastructure.

Power Vacuum Trigger

- Opens when any unit with domain rating 4+ is removed, collapses, or vacates.
- Vacuum window lasts 2 cycles.
- All units in adjacent domains may Contest — no Spy required.
- At the end of 2 cycles the unit with the highest total Contest result claims the infrastructure.

Resolution

Each contesting unit rolls Edge + their relevant domain rating each cycle of the Vacuum window. Results accumulate over both cycles. Highest total wins. Ties go to the unit with the higher Grit — they hold on longer.

What Is Claimed

The claiming unit inherits the abandoned infrastructure — the named assets, contacts, and operations the previous unit held. They do not inherit the domain rating itself — that must be grown. But they start with the infrastructure that normally would take cycles to establish.

Trait Interaction

Opportunistic: +2 Edge on all Contest actions — this is exactly what this trait lives for.

Expansionary: Contest actions cost no Disruption Tokens on existing Grow timers.

Cautious: Will not Contest unless Vacuum is in their primary domain.

Ambitious: +2 Edge on Contest when the Vacuum includes a faction leadership position.

RECRUIT

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
None

Recruit brings a new unit into a faction or draws an existing unit from another faction into your own. It is the primary mechanism for faction growth through personnel rather than domain rating growth.

Recruiting a New Unit

- Creates a new unit at Level 1 in the recruiting faction's primary domain.
- New unit inherits one trait from the faction's dominant trait profile.
- Takes 2 cycles for the new unit to become active.
- Faction must have available capacity to absorb the new unit.

Recruiting an Existing Unit

- Targets a unit currently affiliated with another faction.
- Requires a prior Targeted Spy to identify the target unit's current situation.
- Resolution: recruiter rolls Edge + Influence domain (if available) or primary domain.
- Target resists with Grit + Loyalty modifier (Loyal trait adds +3 to resistance).
- On success: unit joins as member. If they were the leader of their old faction — Leadership Vacuum opens immediately.
- On failure: target's current faction is alerted that a recruitment attempt was made.

Trait Interaction

Open (faction trait): Recruit actions cost half normal cycles — easy to join.

Insular (faction trait): Cannot Recruit outside the faction's established networks without -2 penalty.

Ambitious: +2 on Recruiting units with high domain ratings — they want the best around them.

SEEK LEADERSHIP

Type
Conflict

Stat Used
Edge

Gated By
Must be faction
member

Seek Leadership is the action used by a unit to claim leadership of a leaderless faction or to challenge an existing leader. It is the primary mechanism for resolving faction leadership crises and the action most strongly weighted for Ambitious trait units.

Seeking Leadership of a Leaderless Faction

- Unit must be a member of the faction.
- Resolution: unit rolls Edge + primary domain rating vs. Leadership Need score of the faction.
- Higher Leadership Need = lower resistance = easier to claim.
- If multiple units Seek Leadership in the same cycle, they contest against each other directly.
- Winner becomes faction leader. Leadership Need resets to zero.
- Faction immediately stabilizes — volatile leaderless behavior ends.

Challenging an Existing Leader

- Unit must be a member of the faction.
- Resolution: challenger rolls Edge + primary domain vs. leader rolls Grit + primary domain.
- If challenger wins decisively (margin 3+): leader is replaced immediately.
- If challenger wins narrowly: leader is weakened — Unstable condition on their leadership for 2 cycles.
- If leader wins: challenger is exposed. Leader may expel them from the faction without a further action.

Leadership Need Accumulation

Each cycle leaderless	+2 Leadership Need
External attack on faction	+3 Leadership Need
Faction loses domain rating	+4 Leadership Need
Successful Recruit action	+1 Leadership Need (new members want direction)
Leadership Need becomes visible	At 10+ — visible to all factions. Signals opportunity.
Leadership Need cap	20 — faction begins fragmenting. Splinter risk each cycle.

Trait Interaction

Ambitious: +2 Edge on all Seek Leadership actions. Leadership Need threshold to act is halved.

Loyal: Will not challenge an existing leader unless faction is in crisis (Stability below 4).

Opportunistic: +1 Edge on Seek Leadership when Leadership Need is above 10.

Satisfied: Will not Seek Leadership unless Leadership Need is at maximum and no other unit acts.

5. World Chaos

World Chaos is a GM-controlled modifier that injects unpredictability into the simulation. It is not an action taken by a unit — it is a condition set by the GM that affects how actions resolve this cycle. World Chaos represents the city at a moment of volatility: something in the air, a confluence of pressures, the conditions that make extraordinary things possible.

5.1 — Setting Chaos

Each cycle the GM sets a Chaos level from 0 to 10 in one or more specific domains. Chaos is domain-targeted — the GM chooses which domain is volatile, not which unit is affected.

Chaos 0	No effect. Normal cycle.
Chaos 1–3	Background noise. City feels restless. Small chance a random unit gets an extraordinary action.
Chaos 4–6	Moderate volatility. Something will probably happen. GM knows it's coming — not who or what.
Chaos 7–9	High volatility. An extraordinary action is likely. Possibly multiple. City is on edge.
Chaos 10	Maximum. Extraordinary action guaranteed. May affect multiple units. Everything is on fire.

5.2 — The Extraordinary Action

When World Chaos fires, the system selects a random unit operating in the targeted domain — weighted toward lower-rated units, since extraordinary events tend to elevate the unexpected rather than amplify the already-powerful. The selected unit's action this cycle resolves as if their domain rating were 3 levels higher than it actually is.

The Core Effect

A Domain 3 unit acts like a Domain 6 unit. In logarithmic weight terms: 6 points acting like 84 points. This is not a small bump — it is a city-shaking event from an unexpected source.

The extraordinary action still fires through the unit's trait weights. Chaos amplifies who the unit is — it does not replace their personality or override their goals. A Cautious unit getting a chaos boost makes an extraordinarily effective defensive move, not a sudden aggressive attack.

5.3 — The GM Does Not Choose the Unit

This is the critical design constraint. The GM sets the chaos level and the domain. The system selects the unit. Even the GM is surprised by the outcome. This prevents Force Action overreach and keeps the simulation feeling emergent rather than authored.

Design Intent

The GM sets conditions. The city responds.

Chaos is a weather tool, not a targeting tool.

If the GM wants a specific unit to act extraordinarily, that is a Force Action — not Chaos.

The surprise is the point.

5.4 — Chaos Hangover

After a World Chaos event fires, the Chaos level automatically drops by 2 in that domain the following cycle. The city needs to process what just happened. The GM can override this and maintain high Chaos — but consecutive high-Chaos cycles generate compounding cascade chains that become increasingly difficult to predict or control.

1 Chaos cycle	Single extraordinary event. City absorbs it. Chaos -2 next cycle.
2 consecutive Chaos cycles	Two events compound. Cascade chains begin. Attention likely elevated.
3+ consecutive Chaos cycles	City in crisis. Multiple cascades active simultaneously. GM loses narrative control. This is by design.

5.5 — Chaos Visibility

The Chaos level is hidden from units and factions by default. The GM may choose to reveal it as a narrative signal — 'something feels wrong in the city tonight' — but the mechanical value is never surfaced to players directly. The GM tool in the app shows Chaos levels across all domains on a dashboard visible only to the GM.

6. Quick Reference

All Actions at a Glance

GROW	Increase domain rating. Decimal progress tracking. Disruption Tokens on interruption. Spy resistance decays with completion %. Cap resistance above 85%.
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ASSIST	Boost another unit's Grow (10% per level) or active action (half rating additive). Creates one-way exposure.
ENTRENCH	Build roots in a domain. +0.10 Entrench score. All domains Level 2+. SM also prevents decay. Full action slot — cannot act or defend same cycle.
SPY (Passive)	Half domain rating. Same domain only. General activity revealed. Does NOT satisfy Spy gate.
SPY (Targeted)	Full domain rating. Any domain if logic holds. Specific intel. Satisfies Spy gate for aggression.
OBSCURE	Split domain rating between action and concealment. OR use different domain at full cost. Hides from Spy.
EXPOSE	SM only. Unmask Anon unit. Requires prior Targeted Spy. Anon doubles Grit resistance.
BLOCK (City-Wide)	Half domain rating. Affects all units in domain. No Spy required. Generates Attention.
BLOCK (Specific)	Full domain rating. One target. Requires Targeted Spy. More surgical, more powerful.
ATTACK	Reduce target domain rating by 1. Requires Targeted Spy. Margin 3+ decisive. Margin 1-2 Unstable.
STEAL	Transfer 1 domain level from target to self. Requires Targeted Spy. Always traceable.
DEFEND	Fortify domain vs Attack/Steal. Split own rating OR use different domain at full strength.
CONTEST	Claim Power Vacuum. Free action during 2-cycle window. Edge + domain, highest total wins.
RECRUIT	Add new unit to faction OR draw existing unit from another faction. Targeted Spy required for existing units.
SEEK LEADERSHIP	Claim leadership of leaderless faction OR challenge existing leader. Must be faction member.

Stat Used by Action

Edge (offensive)	Grow, Assist, Spy, Expose, Block, Attack, Steal, Contest, Recruit, Seek Leadership
Grit (defensive)	Entrench, Obscure, Defend — and all resistance rolls regardless of action type

Gate Summary

Spy gate	Block (Specific), Attack, Steal, Expose — all require prior successful Targeted Spy
Domain gate	Must hold Level 1 in domain to act in it
Steal domain gate	Must hold Level 1 in target domain before Stealing into it

Contest gate	Power Vacuum must be active in that domain
Leadership gate	Must be faction member to Seek Leadership
Entrench gate	Must hold Level 2+ in domain to take Entrench action

Entrench Quick Reference

Level change UP	Entrench $\times$ 0.25 — unfamiliar territory, most roots lost
Level change DOWN	Entrench $\times$ 1.25 (cap 1.00) — returning to known ground, roots deepen
Entrench action	+0.10 to Entrench score
Zero floor rule	Entrench 0.00 at start AND end of cycle → rating drops 0.10
Defense bonus	Entrench 0.26–0.50: +1 Grit / 0.51–0.75: +2 Grit / 0.76–1.00: +3 Grit